

Chapter 11 — Crowdsourcing versus expert annotation

Representation learning and weak labels still leave a workforce question: who should annotate which items?

Learning objectives

- By the end of this part

Crowdsourcing advantages

- For annotation, crowdsourcing offers scale, lower per-item cost, fast turnaround
- Those advantages matter most when the schema is simple, guidelines are clear
- This section emphasizes when experts must own labels rather than restating platform

Example 11.16 — Crowd Scale for Attribute Labels

- Example 11.16 — hands-on module
- Example 11.16 shows crowd scale for high-volume attribute labeling
- A vision team needs millions of face images tagged with age band, expression
- Crowdsourcing platforms distribute the schema across many workers so labeling finishes in
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter11/example16/``

Example 11.17 — Crowd Cost for Product Images

- Example 11.17 — hands-on module
- Example 11.17 contrasts crowd cost with expert-only product labeling
- A retailer needs thousands of product photos labeled for category and attributes
- Paying only domain experts would blow the budget
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter11/example17/``

Crowdsourcing challenges

- Crowd workers may be inconsistently trained or motivated, producing noisy annotations
- Mitigation requires ground-truth checks, gold questions, and redundancy
- Platform ethics and inter-annotator agreement controls from earlier chapters should be in

Example 11.20 — Expert Quality for Radiology Labels

- Example 11.20 — hands-on module
- Expert annotation uses specialists for tasks that need deep domain knowledge
- Example 11.20 shows why expert quality matters for clinical images
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter11/example20/``

Example 11.22 — Legal Experts for Contract Clauses

- Example 11.22 — hands-on module
- Experts also improve consistency on complex legal schemas
- Example 11.22 keeps legal clause labeling with domain experts
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter11/example22/``

Expert challenges

- Expert annotation is expensive and hard to scale because skilled professionals are scarce
- Careful analysis also slows throughput
- Which motivates hybrid designs in the next part

Takeaways

- Crowds excel at scale, cost, and speed on clear schemas with gold checks
- Experts excel at precision and consistency on radiology, legal
- Expert-only staffing hits cost and capacity walls

Next

- Complete the quiz for this part
- The next part covers hybrid annotation pipelines